The Afflicted Girls

By Nicole Cooley

INTRODUCTION

Wallace Stevens once observed that "poetry is a scholar's art." Nicole Cooley's book of poetry entitled "The Afflicted Girls" melds both poetry and research to examine the events of Salem in 1692 from a variety of perspectives--the accusers', the accused's, bystanders'--those whose lives were forever changed by the accusations, trials, and executions. The Afflicted Girls by Nicole Cooley studies first, the accused witch, Tituba. Like the colored race generally and especially of the tropics, Tituba was a believer in the occult.

The sky is a palm spread open, sheltering
nobody. An egg-yolk yellow moon floats over
the cage of men
in the middle of Bridgetown's market: a display
of runaway slaves. When I walk along the margin

of the beach, I don't look at them.
I don't look at *Gift of God*, the waiting ship,
its principal cargo salted fish, sugar, slaves.
Instead I watch the water stutter against rocks.

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In Salem, the New World sticks to my tongue
like wool. I can't breathe
in the Reverend's house. I can't sleep
in the bed beside his daughter,
her flushed skin limned with sweat
in the cold room.

Each morning, Family Prayer, a circle
of bowed heads as the Reverend explains
the fallen world, this land infected by black devils.

Afterward I walk to the marsh to watch
the water separating here from home.
The sky shuts its fist.

In the dark, feel along the edge
of history's body
to find the place in which local legend
becomes the truest story.

Touch the small, painful ache
where myths originate.
Rub your fingers on it like a scab.

TRANSITION

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We know that Tituba had been brought to Massachusetts from Barbados and enjoyed a reputation in the neighborhood for her skills in the magic arts. According to Charles Upham (1867) The details of her statement cover nearly the whole ground of them. While indicating, in most respects, a mind at the lowest level of general intelligence, they give evidence of cunning and wariness in the highest degree. The Examination of Tituba

Court: Tituba what evil spirit have you familiarity with
Tituba: none
Court: why do you hurt these children
Tituba: I do not hurt them
Court: who is it then
Tituba: the devil for ought I know

The Reverend's hand spreads open over my back.
He could reach inside
my body, drag words from my lungs,
force my silence out.

His fingers circle my wrists. His ribs
lock over mine, press me against the pantry wall.
His voice, pure threat. *Confess.*

Upstairs, his daughter spins and twists
in bed, calls out my name.

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Later I will hold her tightly
while she shudders in my lap.

Court: doe you see who it is that torments these children now
Tituba: yes it is goode good she hurts them in her own shape
Court: & who is it that hurts them now
Tituba: I am blind noe I cannot see

Find the gap,
the rip in the paper. Pull out the stitches.
Stretch open the loops of thread.

Wait in the pantry, the garden
where she once waited.
Follow the path's wet slate to the harbor.

Stand on the rocks and let go of the story.
The body sinks to the soft ocean floor.

Here is the fallen world. Here is the village
where children choke and cry out
in their sleep, as her voice breaks
in the shore's throat, as fiction spins into fact.

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Can the historians be trusted . . . are the facts as we know them truly facts or were they perhaps altered by well meaning Puritan ancestors to cloak the truth in mystery. After all, the ink fades quickly in "The Waste Book"

must always be recopied twice,
the pen a shovel turning the earth's surface, opening

the page to another version of history.
In the meetinghouse a man corrects

church records, head bent to the paper
that will offer us this past, this

story while at the end of another century
a woman watches her study window

like a movie screen, her garden's beds
turning to torn, yellowed paper. She is ready

to erase her own story, cross out
her voice, blur her words to nothing

but stiff ink. What relief, she thinks,
to step outside her body, to leave

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herself, to transcribe the archive's directions:

one or two words missing.
name illegible, possibly John.
name completely missing.
this whole last line has been struck out.

as if only the voices hold her own speech
together, as if the voices cancel out her own.

In the other century, pages stack and settle
as the man works alone all night, retracing

parish records like a repeated prayer:

August 28 by an Order from the Governor and Council was observed as a day of Fasting and Prayer, to seek mercy from God in relation to the present afflicted state of things in both Englands.

We should know the woman
is all wrong when she calls the past an empty

plate she can rinse clean, snow-covered
road she watches from her window.

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No -- each page marks a plot, a burial ground,
each word a seed needling the dirt.

TRANSITION

Joining Tituba as one of the accused was Dorcas Good, who had been seen by the girls flying around the countryside on her "pole," and who was sneaking into their bedrooms at night and biting them. A cunning witch, Dorcas Good must have been, and apparently wise beyond her years. When accused sorceress Dorcas Good joined her mother Sarah in Ipswich jail, she was only 5 years old. Nicole Cooley proposes a bleak future in the life of this young child in Torn, 1710.

Far from the thatched roof of my father's
house I lean into the wind swallow

cold in order to remember
the glare of light on ice outside the jail's window

Petition for Damages September 13, 1710
The humble representation of Will'm Good of the Damage {torn}
by reason of the sufferings of his family {torn}
supposed Witchcraft

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to remember Mother Sister while Father
waits in the house where I don't

live waits at the table alone plates set
along the edges for No Family

being chain'd in the dungeon so hardly used and terrifyed {torn}
she hath ever since been very chargeable having little or no reason
to govern herself {torn}

Now in these woods far from my father
I live in this body that isn't mine

O Roof O Field of Snow
O Father's Bone White Plate
O Mother Sister

Fear seeps under the door of my father's house
to the place at the table where he writes

Out here I have the voice that I won back --
nothing but emptiness --

O No Family No Mother No Sister Dead

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AWARD HISTORY

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